THE MONKEYPOX FAQ

What is Monkeypox?
Part of the same genus as smallpox, the virus was first found in research monkeys in 1958 and the first reported case was identified in the Democratic Republic of Congo, in Africa. It is endemic in 11 African countries.



How does it spread?
A viral zoonosis, it transmits mostly from animals to humans, through a bite or scratch or contact with body fluids or contaminated bedding. Human to human transmission is rarer, and can spread through contact of body fluid or contaminated objects. It has an incubation period of 5 to 21 days



What are its symptoms?
Fever, bodyache, fatigue and rash. It is also characterised by the swelling of the lymph nodes

How do you treat monkeypox?
The US has recognised the potential of three antivirals–Cidofovir, Brincidofovir and Tecovirimat



Is there a vaccine for monkeypox?
The vaccine for smallpox is 95 per cent effective against the virus if taken in the past 20 years. Studies on booster shots still ongoing

Can one die of monkeypox?
Fatality rate is 1-11 per cent. Death is usually due to complications such as respiratory or heart failure, or hepatitis

How many cases of monkeypox have been reported so far?
As on May 24, the WHO had confirmed 92 cases in 12 countries worldwide where the disease was not endemic. India has not reported any case so far, but the authorities are not taking any chances

Will we have a monkeypox pandemic?



Unlikely, as monkeypox has a far lower transmission rate (3-30 per cent) compared to Covid-19 (over 90 per cent in some areas). It is, therefore, far less contagious than Covid

will help in surveillance, treatment and vaccine development. The Union ministry of health and family welfare (MoHFW) has directed the two disease watchdogs—NCDC (National Centre for Disease Control) and ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research)—to keep a close eye on the situation.

However, experts say the disease is unlikely to become a global pandemic like Covid-19. Estimated transmission rates range from 3-30 per cent compared to over 90 per cent in some areas for Covid-19. This is mostly because it spreads differently from Covid-19. "There are two ways in which it spreads," says Dr Deswal, "from animals to humans through a bite or scratch, contact of body fluid, indirect contact (say, with the contaminated bedding of the animal); and from humans to humans via direct contact of body fluids or touching a patient's infected rashes or indirect contact via contaminated clothes." The disease can also spread through respiratory droplets as in Covid-19, but these are far heavier than Covid and don't travel as much distance or be as contagious. "The safest would be to not be in the same room as an infected person without protective gear," Dr Deswal adds. Overall, human-to-human transmission of the monkeypox virus has been very rare in the past 70 years.

Monkeypox has symptoms similar to but milder than smallpox. It, too, is characterised by fever, bodyache, chills and fatigue. However, unlike smallpox, monkeypox results in a swelling of the lymph nodes. A person can exhibit any of these symptoms, but the disease, like the one caused by Covid-19, is usually self-limiting. The symptoms, though, are far more recognisable than in Covid, as they manifest in rashes on the skin. "These start as bumps and then turn into fluid-filled tubes, which then become scabs and fall off," explains Dr Kirti Sabnis, infectious disease specialist at the Fortis hospital in Kalyan, Mumbai. Monkeypox also has a longer incubation period of 5-21 days unlike 5-7 days in the case of Covid's Omicron variant or the 2-14 days for the Wuhan strain.

Though not fatal in itself, complications caused by the symptoms—such as respiratory failure, hepatitis, even heart attacks—can result in mortality. Depending on the strain of the virus—there are two, the West African clade and the Congo Basin (Central African) clade—WHO estimates a mortality of between 1 and 11 per cent. In the past year, it pegged case fatality to be between 3 and 6 per cent. "Treatment is usually symptomatic and includes a combination of antibiotics and antivirals, fever medicine and skin ointment," says Dr Deswal. The CDC (Centers for Disease Control & Prevention) in the US has recognised the potential of three antivirals in its treatment—Cidofovir, Brincidofovir and Tecovirimat. Although studies on their efficacy against monkeypox are still ongoing, these drugs had had some success in the treatment of smallpox. Experts say India must begin to invest resources in stockpiling essential drugs and testing kits for the virus. "It is hard to determine what scale of the disease we might see in India," says Dr Sabnis.

Given its similarity to smallpox, the smallpox vaccine is up to 95 per cent effective against monkeypox if taken in the past 20 years. However, experts caution against re-taking the smallpox vaccine to protect against monkeypox till more medical studies are done on the subject. "We know it protects against smallpox and, to some extent, monkeypox. But we should wait and see what the medical guidelines on the vaccination will be, and if we even need to be worried. There is no need to panic," says Dr Sabnis. Like the Covid-19 pandemic has taught us, only time and information can help reduce anxiety about the outbreak of fresh diseases. ■